PRELUDE VI

THIS Prelude suggests to the pianist a lively rendering, and nothing the pianoforte can do with it is more brilliant and exciting than its effect on the clavichord, allowing, of course, for the tiny tone of the old instrument, which, however, has within its limits surprising powers of accent and swell. The harpsichord can also give an excellent account of this and of various other movements in Book II.

The British Museum autograph is not Bach's final version in all points; but in it we catch him in the act of inserting the demisemiquavers in bars 22 and 24. These demisemiquavers are no more melodic than the *arpeggios* they fill out. They constitute a brilliant instrumental effect producible on the pianoforte, as on the clavichord and harpischord, by fingers lifted high and sharply withdrawn; an action possible in the most rapid *tempo*, so that here these demisemiquavers are no warning signal against break-neck speed. The only such warning may be found in bars 13-16 and 34-40. Not until these passages are mastered beyond suspicion of scrambling should the player decide upon his *tempo*, and he must then make a decision which requires no sophisticated broadening on the pretext that the difficult passages have more expression than the rest. They have; but the flow is torrential.

In bars 5 and 26 the semiquavers in the right hand demand the emphasis of a fresh entry, but the left hand joins as belonging to the same part. Similarly the right and left hand are a single part throughout bars 53-54. And in bar 56 the Bass A fills the gap in the upper part.

Quavers are *staccato* throughout, but more vocally so in bars 9-17 and 35-38 than elsewhere; while a swelling *legato* is required for the chromatic scale in bars 40-41, and perhaps for the scale in bars 55-56.

Mordents, usually a very deliberate melodic ornament, are in this Prelude as sharp as possible, except in bars 43-45, where the slow descent of the melodic outline over the dominant pedal has great rhetorical power. Here it is even advisable to make the mordent in bar 44 (as well as the others) with a whole tone instead of a semitone, thus accentuating the melodic descending minor scale.

The bracketed slurs in bars 18-26 are adopted from the very interesting authenticated ones in bars 43-45, which indicate knots of concentrated tone in an otherwise light finger *staccato*.

FUGUE VI

THE Countersubject, beginning in the second half of bar 3, and providing a specially fine contrast to the Subject, ends with a formula which, in combination with a new figure in the third voice and the cadential notes of the Subject, gives rise from bar 7½ onwards to the two short Episodes

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(bars 8-9 and 12-13) and to the cascade (bars 22-24) at the end of the long Episode 3. The rolling triplets of the Subject are already inverted in bar 5 before the entry of the third voice; and in bar 10 the Subject drifts in during the course of a close-knit dialogue on this figure, direct and inverted. Such dialogue may lead in *crescendo* to entries of the whole Subject, but should not in this kind of Fugue be so emphatic as to mask them. The real systematic Stretto soon appears in bars 14-15 between the middle voice and the treble at one crotchet in the upper fifth. In bars 17-18 the same Stretto is given with the Inverted Subject, between middle and bass in the lower fifth. From this arises the long Episode 3, beginning in bar 18 with a graceful dialogue, on the triplet figures and something more. Do not confine the phrases to the triplet, but regard them as including the three indolently swinging quavers which adjoin them. This Episode culminates by resuming the other episodic material, and, descending into deep regions (implying on the clavichord sonorous tone), ends in bar 25 with an incident like that in bar 10, from which, accordingly, arises the final entry of the Subject, joined in the deep bass by the Countersubject.

The *tempo* should be a very flowing eight in the bar, or a four so deliberate as to make the contrast between triplets and square rhythms interesting. With the exception of the quavers in Episode 3, there is room for little but *legato* touch; but there is unlimited scope for swells and contrasts of colour.